

AN INK-WASH SAMURAI DUEL · ANDROID & WEB

影ノ誓

Kage no Chikai · Oath of the Shadow

Six names in a burnt ledger. Then a seventh.

▶ Play free: embermak.github.io/kage-no-chikai/play

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THE PREMISE

Six names in a burnt ledger. Then a seventh.

A home burns. A son survives with a ledger of six names, the men who lit the fire. He becomes Kage, the shadow, and the oath becomes the only thing he carries.

Book One is a quiet, restrained revenge road across a harsh northern land: one name, one duel, one chapter at a time. No speeches. Just snow, ink and steel.

Book Two, *The Seventh Name*, burns the ledger's margin open. His sister Yuki survived. A seventh mark carries the seal of his own family. The road ends at the family grave, with a choice and two endings.



A FULL GAME IN ABOUT 2 MB

What's inside

12	45	38	42	59	2
Chapters	Duels	Named foes	Weapons	Outfit pieces	Endings

Arrow-based parry

Each enemy strike shows a direction. Swipe along it. A timing ring grades you Parry, Great or Perfect; a perfect parry slows time and arms a ×1.5 counter.

42 weapons, 10 styles

Katana, nodachi, twin kodachi, yari, kusarigama, kanabo, tessen, nagamaki and more, each with its own speed, reach and perks.

Endless Survival

One health bar, infinite foes, rising difficulty. Win a round and you heal a little before the next one walks in.

REAL GAMEPLAY

From the duel itself



始め — the Castle Ashigaru winds up. Swipe along the arrow.



Every foe has its own arrow attack set.



Unblockable: no parry. BACK or JUMP.



Survival: one life, endless foes.

I

The update that broke the game

Identity · v1 recovery

Problem. Players loved the first Kage no Chikai, and asked for more: more weapons, harder enemies, a better story. I gave them a big update, and in it I replaced the arrow-based parry with a new combat system. The feedback was instant and honest: it did not feel like the same game anymore.

Fix. I went back and recovered the original v1 duel code, line for line, and rebuilt every new feature on top of the untouched core: 8 weapons at the time, new enemies, story, Survival and outfits. The lesson I will keep forever: know what your game *is*, and protect it.

II

“The story is cringe”

Rewrite · restraint

Problem. That was the exact word a tester used. They were right. The first story explained everything and felt loud.

Fix. I rewrote it with a grounded, restrained tone, inspired by the quiet revenge stories I love, with fully original characters. Fewer words, more silence, short lines before and after each duel. Then Book Two added a twist I had to earn: a seventh name.

III

Too easy

`Enemy HP · feints · fair tells`

Problem. Players finished fights too fast. The enemies hit slowly and died quickly, and nobody felt any danger.

Fix. I raised enemy HP across the board and taught them feints, delayed strikes and unblockable attacks. To stay fair, every unblockable gets a clear tell and every wind-up is capped at 2 seconds, so hard never means cheap. An AI self-test now fights all 45 duels with 4 weapons to check the curve.

IV

Characters that felt static

`SF2-inspired procedural animation`

Problem. The silhouettes looked like paper cut-outs. In a game that is all silhouette, that is fatal.

Fix. Inspired by Shadow Fight 2, I wrote a procedural animation pass with bending limbs, a breathing stance that shifts weight, steps into strikes, a unique swing per weapon, blade trails, stagger, knockdowns, dodge hops, limp death falls and cloaks that sway.

V

Born from a 219 MB lesson

2D vs 3D

Problem. Kage no Chikai exists because my 3D project, ASHBORN in Unreal Engine 5, shipped a 219 MB first APK that felt like a tech demo. I fought that build down below 95 MB, and learnt how much size costs players.

Fix. So this game took the opposite road: a canvas, an ink brush and about 2 MB. It got better reviews than the 3D game, and that changed how I think about what to build next.

VI

2 MB, native feel

Lean wrapper · JS haptics bridge

Problem. A web game can feel like a web page. I wanted it to feel like a phone game: instant, tactile, offline.

Fix. I replaced Capacitor with a lean WebView wrapper that my own build kit compiles without the Android SDK, bundled subset fonts so it looks the same everywhere, and wired native vibration through a JS bridge with about 30 patterns. Add a parry timing ring, three parry tiers, slow-motion and counters, and the whole thing still fits in about 2 MB.

WHAT I LEARNT

Lessons I am keeping

Protect the core

Add everything around the thing players love. Never through it.

Listen, then translate

“Cringe” and “too easy” are gifts. Turn them into specific, testable changes.

Hard, but fair

Difficulty comes from reading the enemy, not from surprises you could not see.

Small is a feature

Two megabytes means anyone can try it in seconds, on any phone.

Next: more small, lightweight phone games that are genuinely fun. Quick to download, easy to pick up, hard to put down.

PLAY IT NOW

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Showcase & dev story	embermak.github.io/kage-no-chikai
Play in browser	embermak.github.io/kage-no-chikai/play
Android APK · 2.8 MB	embermak.github.io/kage-no-chikai/KageNoChikai-v3.0.1.apk

> An experimental project, not launching on the stores. Curious about the source code or want to collaborate? Message me on LinkedIn or email maikeicheong@gmail.com.